QUEENSLAND ACADEMY OF SPORT · PANEL INTERVIEW

FIRST 90 DAYS

High Performance Manager for Surfing, Skate, Paddle and Triathlon

LISTEN
People, environments and dynamics

MAP
Where I fit and what each sport needs

CONNECT
QAS support to each sport's plan

AGREE
One plan and a review rhythm

REVIEW
Progress, reporting and investment

SIMON THOMAS

Thursday 15 October 2026

WHERE I START

THE SPORT LEADS AND QAS INVESTS

ASK ME ABOUT

- LEADING THROUGH INFLUENCE
- HOLDING STANDARDS ACROSS SITES
- ALIGNING COMPLEX STAKEHOLDERS

THE SPORT OWNS THE PROGRAM

The NSO and head coach hold the plan and the What It Takes To Win. QAS is a partner in it, not its owner.

THE PSM LEADS THE PEOPLE

Each sport's Performance Support Manager leads its practitioners and coaches. I support them and never go around them.

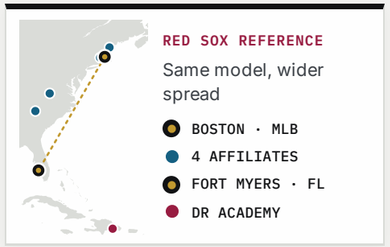
I HOLD THE PARTNERSHIP

Resourcing, alignment and executive reporting, so QAS support does the most good in each sport.

FROM EXPERIENCE Red Sox · 16 practitioners, six sites, no direct delivery

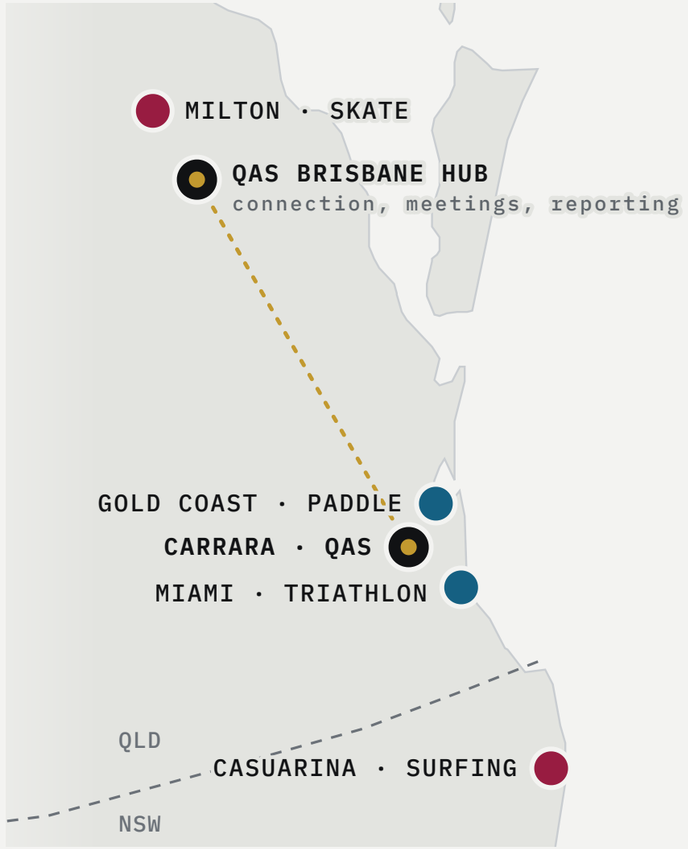
EACH PROGRAM, ENVIRONMENT AND MODEL

FOUR PARTNERSHIPS, FOUR MODELS



ASK ME ABOUT

- SUPPORTING A SPORT FROM OUTSIDE
- WORKING ACROSS CULTURES AND LANGUAGES
- OLYMPIC CAMPAIGN PLANNING



SKATE

Skate Australia. Distributed, young athletes, Gold Coast street facility and the World Skateboarding Tour.

WORLD TOURING

PADDLE

Paddle Australia. Centralised daily squad on the Gold Coast, sprint and para, building to World Cups and Worlds.

WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP

TRIATHLON

AusTriathlon. Newly centralised at the Miami hub with its Ascent Academy, racing the Championship Series.

WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP

SURFING

Surfing Australia. High Performance Centre at Casuarina with QAS practitioners embedded, on the Championship Tour.

WORLD TOURING

FROM EXPERIENCE Brazil and Singapore · supporting national programs from outside

SCHEMATIC, NOT TO SCALE · PUBLIC NSO AND QAS SOURCES

TIMING

NINETY DAYS INSIDE LIVE QUALIFICATION WINDOWS



Ranking or qualifying window · Final qualifying phase · Qualifying event · First 90 days, on a November start

SOURCES: ICF, WORLD TRIATHLON, ISA AND WORLD SKATE LA28 QUALIFICATION SYSTEMS

FIRST 90 DAYS

LISTEN, MAP, THEN AGREE

ASK ME ABOUT

- BUILDING TRUST QUICKLY
- MAPPING DECISION RIGHTS
- LEARNING A NEW SPORT FAST
- LISTENING BEFORE ACTING

DAYS 1 TO 30

LISTEN AND LEARN

- Athletes, staff and the dynamics between functions
- Map where I fit in each scenario
- Every environment, Milton to Casuarina
- Each sport's WITTW, plans and QAS spend

DAYS 31 TO 60

MAP AND CONNECT

- QAS support against WITTW gaps
- What each partner needs from QAS
- Shared needs, touring or centralised
- Reporting that informs decisions

DAYS 61 TO 90 · WHAT YOU WOULD SEE

AGREE AND ACT

- One page plan each sport owns
- A review and reporting rhythm
- QAS investment mapped to 2027
- An honest baseline for QAS HP leadership



The phases overlap. As understanding builds, each one lays the foundations of the next. Nothing is actioned before it is understood and agreed, but priority decisions do not wait sixty days.

WHERE I ADD VALUE AND HOW I CHALLENGE

ADD VALUE, EARN THE RIGHT TO CHALLENGE

ASK ME ABOUT

- INTEGRATED ATHLETE PLANNING
- COACH FEEDBACK SYSTEMS
- BEING A TRUSTED SOUNDING BOARD
- UNSEEN PRESSURE ON STAFF

> *The test: does QAS support help the sport's people make better decisions, or remove something in their way?*

WHERE I ADD VALUE

RESOURCING	Investment follows the gaps in each sport's What It Takes To Win
ALIGNMENT	One plan per athlete across QAS and the NSO
REPORTING	Concise, honest and early to QAS HP leadership
PSM SUPPORT	A peer group, with coach development led through them

HOW CHALLENGE LANDS

AGREE IT EARLY	Ask each PSM and coach how they want to be challenged
ASK, THEN SHOW	Questions and evidence, in private, support in public
RAISE IT EARLY	Name small concerns before caution compounds

FROM EXPERIENCE Crusaders one plan · Western Force sounding board

WHEN TO BECOME INVOLVED AND WHEN TO STEP BACK

OBSERVE, ASK, OFFER, ACT

ASK ME ABOUT

- PROTECTING WHAT WORKS
- BUILDING FROM NOTHING
- OWNERSHIP VERSUS CLARITY
- OWNING THE SYSTEM, NOT THE SESSION



Some people need ownership. Others need clarity, or a responsibility taken off them, so they can act.

I STEP BACK FROM

- Daily coaching and practitioner work
- Decisions inside the agreed plan
- Anywhere my voice only adds noise

I STEP IN ON

- Athlete welfare, safety or integrity
- Investment not serving the plan
- QAS and the NSO pulling apart
- Barriers beyond the sport's reach

FROM EXPERIENCE Red Sox system · Crusaders protect · AG Rugby build

IS EACH PROGRAM ON TRACK?

FIVE LENSES, ONE REPORT

ASK ME ABOUT

- TESTING AND REPORTING SYSTEMS
- APPLIED RESEARCH PARTNERSHIPS
- DATA COACHES CAN ACT ON

NOW
The daily training environment, a mix of development and performance

NEXT
Benchmark events and qualification windows this season

LATER
Progress that sets funding and support towards 2032

LENS	THE QUESTION	EVIDENCE
Performance	Where is each athlete against the sport's winning benchmark?	The sport's WITTW and athlete IPPs
Progression	Is each athlete inside the LA28 picture, and on course for 2032?	Rankings, results and categorisation
Availability	Are athletes healthy and able to train and compete?	Load, injury and illness
Environment	Are coaches, staff and athletes thriving?	PSM check ins and reviews
Investment	Is QAS support producing a return for the sport?	Spend against the plan

MONTHLY WITH EACH PSM · QUARTERLY WITH EACH NSO · ONE CONCISE REPORT TO QAS HP LEADERSHIP

THE SPORT LEADS AND QAS INVESTS. MY JOB IS TO MAKE THAT PARTNERSHIP WORTH MORE TO EVERY ATHLETE.